Competitive Landscape

Competitive Positioning Map

The proposed map uses two dimensions: campus specificity, ranging from general restaurant information to campus-focused dining information, and clarity of current item availability, ranging from scheduled menus or general hours to confirmed item status with visible update times.

UTEP Dining occupies the campus-focused side. The reviewed pages provided campus locations, hours, menu dates, and dietary filters. Current item availability could not be confirmed during the walkthrough, so its position on that dimension remains uncertain.

Nutrislice supports campus-focused dining through individual university implementations. The reviewed UNH documentation described detailed menus and nutrition tools. Its handling of current availability remains unverified because a live menu walkthrough was not completed.

Google Maps occupies the broader restaurant-discovery side, covering options on and off campus. The reviewed profile provided hours, directions, reviews, and a website link, but did not establish current item availability.

DineCheck's intended position is campus-focused information with clearly distinguished location, counter, and item status. This is a target position, not a demonstrated capability.

Comparison of Alternatives

UTEP Dining Website

Competitor type: Direct competitor and existing campus alternative.

Capabilities: Campus dining locations, operating hours, a "What's Open Now" section, menu dates, nutrition information, and dietary and allergen filters.

Strength: It already brings campus-specific dining information together. DineCheck cannot claim that campus hours or dietary filters are unique.

Observed gap: The reviewed menu area did not provide enough information to distinguish scheduled items from food currently available at the counter.

Potential switching reason: Students might choose DineCheck if it provides clearer, dependable item status and update times that help prevent unsuccessful trips.

DineCheck's disadvantage: The existing campus portal already provides useful information. DineCheck has not demonstrated a reliable staff update process or a better decision-making experience.

Nutrislice

Competitor type: Direct competitor offering digital dining menus.

Capabilities: UNH's published descriptions included daily menus, food descriptions, nutrition information, dietary and allergen filters, a nutrition calculator, and favorite locations.

Strength: Its documented tools overlap substantially with DineCheck's proposed features.

Evidence gap: The review did not verify how a live implementation communicates sold-out items, update times, or outdated information. These are questions to investigate rather than confirmed weaknesses.

Potential switching reason: Students might prefer DineCheck if testing demonstrates a quicker workflow and more useful current availability information.

DineCheck's disadvantage: DineCheck remains a proposed solution. It has not demonstrated that its information is more dependable or its workflow easier than Nutrislice's tools.

Google Maps

Competitor type: Indirect competitor for restaurant discovery and navigation.

Capabilities: The reviewed Crave Kitchen & Bar profile displayed opening status, hours, an address, reviews, directions, and a restaurant website link.

Strength: It helps students discover and reach dining options both on and off campus.

Observed gap: The reviewed profile did not establish whether a particular food item was currently available.

Potential switching reason: Students might consult DineCheck when they need to confirm a campus food item or counter's serving status before leaving.

DineCheck's disadvantage: Its proposed campus scope is narrower. Google Maps also provides directions, reviews, and broader restaurant discovery. Students may use both services rather than replace Maps.

Familiar Routines and Asking Employees

Alternative type: Existing student behavior.

Capabilities: Students rely on familiar locations, inspect food on arrival, or ask employees about ingredients and availability.

Strength: Familiar routines require little effort. Employees can clarify information that online descriptions leave uncertain.

Observed gap: Students may discover a closed kitchen, sold-out item, or unsuitable meal only after arriving.

Potential switching reason: DineCheck could be useful when a student wants a particular item, has a short break, or faces unusual hours.

DineCheck's disadvantage: Checking another tool adds effort. Interview 3 suggests that minor availability problems may not justify changing an established routine.

Ranked Switching Triggers

These rankings are working priorities based on the three interview records. They are not campus-wide preference rankings or validated adoption results.

1 Preventing a Wasted Trip During a Short Break

Interview 1 described about 12 minutes lost after visiting an open cafe whose kitchen had stopped serving.

Switching trigger: A student needs food within a limited break and cannot confirm that a counter is serving.

Required value: DineCheck must provide useful status quickly enough to improve the decision.

2 Confirming a Suitable Item Before Leaving

Interview 2 described a vegetarian bowl that was listed online but sold out upon arrival. The alternative required more walking and about $4 in additional spending.

Switching trigger: A student wants a suitable meal and needs to know whether it is currently available.

Required value: Availability must be dependable, and ingredient information must be clear enough to support the choice.

3 Resolving Unusual Hours or Conflicting Information

The interviews described conflicts between general hours, campus schedules, and date-specific announcements.

Switching trigger: A holiday, school break, or conflicting listing makes normal hours unreliable.

R**equired value:** DineCheck must clearly identify the applicable date, serving status, and information source.

4 Checking for a Specific Item Outside a Regular Routine

Interview 3 suggested interest in checking a tool for a particular item, while expressing little need to check before ordinary visits.

Switching trigger: A student's decision depends on a specific item rather than whatever is available.

Required value: The benefit of checking must exceed the effort of opening another tool.

Conditions Needed for Switching

Reliable updates are necessary for every proposed advantage. Visible update times alone are insufficient if the underlying status is inaccurate. DineCheck needs a practical staff update process and a clear way to communicate uncertain or outdated information.

The next evaluation should compare DineCheck with students' existing methods on the same dining tasks. Useful measures include decision time, correct interpretation of location versus counter status, recognition of outdated information, and whether students return to the tool without prompting.

Sources and Evidence Limits

Zachary Interview Notes.pdf, page 1, provides the three student interview summaries.

Competitors.pdf, pages 1–3, provides the UTEP Dining, Nutrislice, and Google Maps reviews.